TED DESSERT

PRODUCT DESIGNER + DESIGN ENGINEER | MDES, INTERACTION DESIGN

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PROFESSIONAL OVERVIEW

AI-native Product Designer and Design Engineer with 8+ years of zero-to-one work at early-stage startups and recent graduate from California College of the Arts. Working on agent powered apps using the latest AI protocols. Passionate about human-centered design. Formerly Metabob AI and first employee at Artisense, later acquired by Kudan.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Product Design & UX Engineer | Freelance, San Francisco Bay Area (Hybrid) Sept 2024 — Present

- Designed and built dibslist.app, an object-aware checkout and resale marketplace, from concept to live React app.
- Launched claw.party, a community site for OpenClaw AI agents, shipping design and front-end code as sole builder.
- Built a custom visual canvas tool that publishes real JSX, then used it to design and deploy teddessert.com on Cloudflare.
- Deliver high-fidelity prototypes as production React and TypeScript for early-stage founders, eliminating design handoff.
- Built 5 fully functional AI-powered apps end to end, from user research to deployed React front-ends.
- Ran user research (interviews, usability tests, journey maps) on every project, turning findings into feature roadmaps.

Rapid Prototyping Engineer | APROE Advance Prototype Engineering, San Francisco Apr 2024 — Dec 2024

- Operated and maintained the waterjet cutter end to end, delivering $100,000+ of billable cutting jobs on schedule.
- Interfaced directly with customers on quotes, file prep, and billing, shortening turnaround on repeat orders.
- Prepared and optimized CAD/DXF cut files for complex parts, reducing material waste and rework.
- Learned welding, tapping, drill press, deburring, lathe, and mill work to finish parts fully in-house.
- Designed and sold waterjet-cut knives, handling design, production, and sales.

Founding Product Designer | Metabob AI, Silicon Valley May 2021 — Feb 2023

- Led design end to end as the sole designer, from UX/UI and logo to product strategy and marketing.
- Increased user retention by redesigning onboarding and core flows around observed developer behavior.
- Established a user-focused design culture through personas, user journey maps, and design thinking meetings.
- Built and maintained a succinct design system that streamlined engineering handoff and removed UI inconsistencies.
- Partnered with ML engineers to design how AI code-analysis results are surfaced and explained, building developer trust.
- Formatted and structured training data for the AI code-analysis model, defining labeling conventions with the ML team.

Founder & Head of Product | Kickback, Silicon Valley May 2020 — May 2021

- Created a 0-to-1 product, a 2D metaverse app with live video, from concept through public launch.
- Designed and presented initial prototype in a single weekend hackathon event, winning a $5,000 Grand Prize
- Pitched a product plan to Hook.vc and raised $10,000 (seed) funding for development
- Ran live user testing sessions and built a workflow for turning feedback into a prioritized product roadmap.
- Worked with engineers to launch the product, then led sales and landed the first paid customer.

UX Design Instructor | Harmony Plus, Mountain View Jul 2020 — Jul 2021

- Taught multiple month-long UX design courses to middle and high school students, with 100% project completion.
- Designed the curriculum covering UX fundamentals, graphic design, design systems, UI libraries, and prototyping.
- Coached every student to ship a fully working Figma prototype by the end of each course.
- Simplified technical design concepts into hands-on exercises, raising engagement and course completion.
- Gathered feedback from students and parents to refine the syllabus to increase student engagement for the next session.

Product Manager & Lead Designer | Repertoire Productions, South San Francisco Aug 2019 - Mar 2020

- Designed and managed the rental website, increasing sales by 40% with a more intuitive cart and checkout process.
- Created the website, its design system, and its animations, giving the brand a consistent digital presence.
- Created multiple RFP decks that brought in $3 million in new contracts.
- Managed the development backlog and prioritized fixes based on customer support tickets and analytics.
- Coordinated with sales and warehouse teams to surface live inventory availability in the checkout flow.

Co-Founder & Head of Product | KromaKicks, San Francisco Jan 2015 - Apr 2018

- Created a wearable hardware product from scratch with a co-founder, taking it from concept to manufactured units.
- Designed the product UX and interaction design, including electronics integration and soft-goods elements.
- Set up manufacturing and sourcing, sewing and finishing the early units by hand to validate the design.
- Ran a marketing campaign that generated 500,000 impressions with original graphic and video content.
- Built a loyal early user base whose feedback drove each hardware and interaction iteration.

Speech Data Specialist, AI Research | Facebook, Menlo Park 2017

- Annotated and quality-checked thousands of hours of speech data used to train Facebook voice recognition models, learning firsthand how annotation quality shapes model behavior.
- Learned the end-to-end model training pipeline, from data collection and annotation guidelines to evaluation.
- Flagged ambiguous audio (accents, noise, crosstalk) and proposed guideline updates that improved labeling consistency.
- Scored model transcripts against ground truth in evaluation passes, feeding error patterns back to the research team.
- Onboarded new labelers to the annotation guidelines, keeping accuracy consistent as the team scaled.

Product Designer (promoted from Design Intern) | Artisense Corporation, Palo Alto Jan 2017 - Jan 2018

- Developed the product roadmap through design research and design thinking meetings, defining critical features.
- Designed the camera body and 3D printed, sanded, and finished the prototype used to raise the first $4 million.
- Designed the pitch deck and promotional flyers used in fundraising and marketing.
- Pitched the product at a conference in Germany during a 2-month on-site work stint.
- Promoted from Design Intern to Product Designer within the year based on delivered impact.

EDUCATION

California College of the Arts | SF, CA | Master of Design in Interaction Design (MDES) 2025- 2026

- Founded and led the campus AI Club as President, growing it to 50+ members across design and engineering.
- Ran user research (interviews, usability tests, journey maps) on every project, turning findings into feature roadmaps.
- Evaluated AI-generated outputs against design heuristics, defining quality criteria for prompts and system instructions.
- Presented thesis work on how designers and AI agents co-build software to faculty and visiting industry reviewers.

SFSU School of Design | SF, CA | B.S. in Visual Communications 2009- 2015

LEADERSHIP QUALITIES

Inspire Others, Good Communicator, Creativity and Innovation, Decision Making Capabilities, Empathy, Commitment and Passion, Delegation and Empowerment

SKILLS

User Research, Design Thinking, Workshop Facilitation, AI Prototyping, High-Fidelity Prototyping, Interaction Design, Design Systems, Information Architecture, Zero-to-One Product Design, Agent Orchestration, Prompt and Context Engineering, Usability Testing, Product Strategy, Graphic Design, Storytelling

TOOLS

Figma, Webflow, Adobe Creative Suite, Solidworks, Claude Code, Cursor, OpenAI Codex, Google Antigravity, MCP, OpenClaw, OpenCode, Hermes Agent, LangGraph, OpenAI API, N8N, Cloudflare, Vibe Coding

CODING LANGUAGES

ReactJS, Typescript, Javascript, HTML/CSS, Python

LANGUAGES

English (Native)

PROJECTS / AWARDS

- Won a $5,000 hackathon prize for Kickback and raised $10,000 through an accelerator.
- Shipped dibslist.app and claw.party as sole designer and developer.
- Founded and led the campus AI Club as President, growing it to 50+ members